shown their faith in me. It was now time for me to show the same faith in my men. Concurrently, the State Government too constituted an SIT, in which the Army and the SF deposed voluntarily. However, the SIT had no member from the SF as part of the SIT. Expectedly, the report blamed the Army and AR for everything, when clearly the civilians were at fault for the second and third incidents. While accusing the SF of HR violations, the report was strangely silent on the culpability and action to be taken against those who had attacked the SF Team and the AR camp. One of our jawans had also died and many more were injured. What about our human rights? Is our life not precious? The law of the land should apply to all.

The non-cooperation by the locals continued and despite our extending the olive branch, we were making no headway. Oting, the site of the incident, falls under the tribal jurisdiction of the ENPO, as the governing body of six Naga tribes. Due to my earlier association with Nagaland, I requested some of the office-bearers of the ENPO for a meeting, which took place on 22 March 2022, in the Delhi Area Officers' Mess, far from any prying eyes. R Tsapikiu Sangtam, President of the ENPO, Manglang Phom, Gen Secretary and C Bendangmeren Chang, Finance Secretary, attended the meeting, for which I went alone. Over a few drinks, we had a fair and frank, no-holds-barred discussion. While they poured their hearts out, I also made it clear that this impasse wasn't helping anyone. In fact, it was the villagers who were suffering more. The need of the hour I told them was not to enter into a blame game but to start the process of reconciliation and apply salve on these wounds, rather than trying to keep them festering. My meeting them had a salutary effect and they agreed to call off the boycott of the SF. I conveyed this to the IGAR (N), Maj Gen Vikas Lakhera, asking him to meet these office-bearers

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